

Year of the Cicadas

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Figure 1: Fall Scene from Year of the Cicadas

ABSTRACT

Year of the Cicadas is an autoethnographic virtual reality experience that explores how parental grief changes over time. The work is rooted in the co-creator's loss of her six-year-old son in 2004 and the Brood X cicada emergence that followed. When the cicadas returned seventeen years later, their predictable cycle became a way to reflect on how grief reshapes itself, resurfaces, and becomes part of the story a person carries forward. The installation includes a memorial component where visitors write the name of someone they have lost on a small paper cicada and hang it on a tree sculpture.

Index Terms: Virtual Reality (VR), Narrative, Grief, Ambisonic Audio.

1 INTRODUCTION

Year of the Cicadas began with the experience of a co-creator who lost her six-year-old son in the spring of 2004. In the weeks after his death, she spent long hours at his gravesite in a small cemetery near their home, sitting with the quiet stillness that often marks early parental bereavement. Research on child loss describes this period as one in which time feels altered and daily routines disappear as parents absorb the permanence of the loss.

Several weeks later, Brood X periodical cicadas began to emerge. These seventeen-year cicadas surfaced in the millions, covering the trees and headstones throughout the cemetery. Their intense chorus created a sound wall that muffled signs of spring returning, offering a strange mix of comfort and frustration. While she faced the worst moment of her life, the cicadas were reaching their peak. She became haunted by the knowledge that they would return in seventeen

years while her son would not. Would she forget the sound of his voice? Who would she be when they returned if she was no longer his mother?

When the Brood X cicadas re-emerged in 2021, she went back to the same cemetery and sat again with the cicadas. She reflected on how her grief had shifted over nearly two decades, mirroring research describing grief as something continually reconstructed rather than resolved. The seventeen-year span between the two emergences became the framework for Year of the Cicadas, a virtual reality narrative about the evolving nature of grief across time.

2 CONCEPT AND ARTISTIC VISION

The installation examines grief over extended periods. Scholars describe bereaved parents as maintaining ongoing relationships with their child through memory, ritual, and sensory cues. The seventeen-year cicada cycle provided a natural structure for exploring this long view. Their emergence, brief time above ground, and predictable return offered a way to understand how grief moves in cycles, resurfaces, and changes shape. The connection between ecological rhythms and the experience of loss became an important metaphor throughout the work.

The project was created through an autoethnographic process involving reflective writing, ecological field recordings, visits to meaningful sites, and conversations with experts in grief, ecology, sound, and meaning-making. The goal was not to define bereavement but to create a space where players could reflect on how grief becomes part of the story a person carries forward.

3 TEMPORAL STRUCTURE AND ENVIRONMENTS

The experience unfolds across seven scenes drawn from significant moments in the co-creator's life. Some scenes occur during the 2004 and 2021 Brood X emergences, while others reflect memories from the years in between. Cicadas appear throughout, not because they were present in each memory, but because they became a symbolic way to represent time passing and the awareness of the seventeen years that separated the two emergences.

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Figure 2: Opening scene where the player puts out their hand and a cicada lands on it



Figure 3: Spring scene where players gather flowers and write a supportive note for someone grieving

The opening scene places the player outside the cemetery gate in 2004, surrounded by the ambisonic chorus of Brood X. A bicycle radio plays a song sung by the co-creator's daughter and an interview with an entomologist, grounding the player in the moment when the first emergence and the early weeks of grief intersected.²

A second scene brings the player into the cemetery, where cicadas land on their hand or cling to the headstones. Flicking them away reveals short messages that mirror the internal conversations of early bereavement.



Figure 4: Scene where the player pushes the child's belongings down the corridor as they leave the hospital for the last time

Other scenes draw from memories that marked the years between emergences. These include pushing a red wagon of belongings down a hospital corridor while well-meaning voices overlap into a dense soundscape, decorating a winter holiday tree with digitized ornaments and a recording of siblings singing together, cleaning a headstone during an autumn visit, and gathering daisies in a summer field while a small radio plays a meaningful song tied to a supportive gesture from a family member.³

The final scene returns to the cemetery during the 2021 emergence. The trees are taller, more headstones fill the landscape, and cicadas surround the player again. A short reflection describes how memories have remained vivid and how the co-creator continues to be her son's mother. Players place small stones on headstones before the experience closes with a quiet acknowledgment of the next emergence in 2038. Together, these scenes explore themes central to grief scholarship, including meaning-making across time, continuing bonds, linking objects, and the slow reconstruction of identity after profound loss.

4 SOUND AND AMBISONICS

Sound is the center of the installation. Ambisonic field recordings from the 2021 emergence were captured to preserve direction, density, and movement. These recordings form the emotional core of the piece. Localized audio sources, including bicycle radio and analog-textured songs, anchor specific memories within the broader sound field. Overlapping voices, original compositions, and a licensed song deepen the emotional arc. Silence is used intentionally for transition and reflection.

5 IMPLEMENTATION

The installation will be presented with two standalone VR headsets that run the 20-minute experience. A monitor will display a two-dimensional walkthrough with headphones for those who prefer not to use a headset. A facilitator will guide participation and support visitors interacting with the experience. A participatory memorial ritual accompanies the VR piece. Visitors can write the name of someone they have lost on a small paper cicada and hang it on a tree sculpture, creating a shared artwork shaped by collective remembrance that will grow over the course of the conference.

6 REFLECTION AND CONTRIBUTION

Year of the Cicadas aligns with the XR Gallery's focus on works that examine time, memory, and the relationship between ecological and human cycles. Grounded in cicada emergences separated by seventeen years, the installation explores grief as a shifting, enduring part of one's life story. Through sound and memory, the piece offers a way to understand how meaning, story, and connection to the deceased continue to evolve across time.